NOT AN EASY RIDE

KARNATAKA CHIEF MINISTER BASAVARAJ BOMMAI, WHO COMPLETED ONE YEAR IN OFFICE THIS WEEK, FACES THE ONEROUS TASK OF ENSURING THE BJP'S VICTORY IN THE UPCOMING STATE ASSEMBLY ELECTION

By AJAY SUKUMARAN

Basavaraj Bommai usually speaks extempore at public events. The engineer in him has an eye for technical minutiae. Last week, for instance, at the Karnataka Power Corporation's anniversary celebrations in Bengaluru, he recalled, with some degree of detail, how the process of laying the foundation for the state's tallest dam across the river Kali four decades ago had been a particularly tricky job—Bommai had apparently witnessed the dam's construction as an engineering student. Then, he cut to the present with a nonchalant quip that drew a laugh from the audience: topics such as power, power grids and electricity distribution interested him because they were somewhat related to political power. "Political power too is generated... it is only generated in a few places, then it is distributed," the Karnataka chief minister observed. "And it can't be stored... political goodwill can't be stored, it has to be replenished."

Well into an election year, power management is surely Bommai's challenge too. The 62-year-old, who completed a year in office on July 28, faces the uphill task of ensuring that the BJP's supply of goodwill in Karnataka is safe from any peak demand fluctuation. There's a historical basis for this—since the mid-1980s, a ruling party in Karnataka has been able to return to power only on three occasions, twice via coalitions. Even in its current avatar, the BJP had had to play the defection game to topple the Congress-Janata Dal (Secular) or JD(S) coalition to capture power in 2019—one year after the assembly election was held.

Bommai took over as chief minister last July in a surprisingly smooth transition from the BJP's veteran Karnataka leader B.S. Yediyurappa just as the second Covid wave was ebbing. He hit the ground running, as they say, by announcing on Day 1 scholarships for farmers' children, enhancing monthly pensions under social security schemes and setting to work on sprucing up the administration. He also focused on implementing a string of welfare measures for the farmers, women and the young that he had initiated. On the economic front, the post-Covid rebound driven by Karnataka's strong IT services sector helped the state clock 9.5 per cent growth by March 2022. Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) flows into the state were

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